

## First Read: Of Mice and Men

Assigned by: Mr. A

Due: Sep 6, 2023 11:59 PM

[Learning Objectives](#)[Text](#)

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Summary

George and Lennie have set up camp for the night and Lennie wants to hear the story again. George obligingly launches into a tale of how prosperous their future is going to be. Unlike other farm workers who are lonely, George and Lennie are not alone because they have each other; and as soon as they get some money together, they're going to buy their own farm and live off the land. Lennie wants rabbits, furry ones like the ones he saw in Sacramento. As George tells the story, he keeps reminding Lennie to be good and to stay out of trouble. Afterward, George asks Lennie to remember their camping spot. If Lennie gets into trouble at their job at the ranch, George instructs him to come back to this spot and wait for him. As they lay down to sleep by the fire, Lennie continues to talk about rabbits, and George assures him that he can have rabbits in any color he wants.

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Read**Excerpt from Chapter 1**

- 1 Lennie pleaded, "Come on, George. Tell me. Please, George. Like you done before."
- 2 "You get a kick outta that, don't you? Awright, I'll tell you, and then we'll eat our supper. ..."
- 3 George's voice became deeper. He repeated his words **rhythmically** as though he had said them many times before.  
"Guys like us, that work on ranches, are the loneliest guys in the world. They got no family. They don't belong no place. They come to a ranch an' work up a stake and then they go into town and blow their stake, and the first thing you know they're poundin' their tail on some other ranch. They ain't got nothing to look ahead to."
- 4 Lennie was delighted. "That's it—that's it. Now tell how it is with us."
- 5 George went on. "With us it ain't like that. We got a future. We got somebody to talk to that gives a damn about us. We don't have to sit in no bar room blowin' in our jack jus' because we got no place else to go. If them other guys gets in jail they can rot for all anybody gives a damn. But not us."
- 6 Lennie broke in. "*But not us! An' why? Because ....because I got you to look after me, and you got me to look after you, and that's why.*" He laughed delightedly. "Go on now, George!"
- 7 "You got it by heart. You can do it yourself."
- 8 "No, you. I forget some a' the things. Tell about how it's gonna be."

- 9 "O.K. Someday—we're gonna get the jack together and we're gonna have a little house and a couple of acres an' a cow and some pigs and——"
- 10 "*An' live off the fatta the lan'.*," Lennie shouted. "An' have *rabbits*. Go on, George! Tell about what we're gonna have in the garden and about the rabbits in the cages and about the rain in the winter and the stove, and how thick the cream is on the milk like you can hardly cut it. Tell about that, George."
- 11 "Why'n't you do it yourself? You know all of it."
- 12 "No ...you tell it. It ain't the same if I tell it. Go on ...George. How I get to tend the rabbits."
- 13 "Well," said George, "we'll have a big vegetable patch and a rabbit hutch and chickens. And when it rains in the winter, we'll just say the hell with goin' to work, and we'll build up a fire in the stove and set around it an' listen to the rain comin' down on the roof—Nuts!" He took out his pocket knife. "I ain't got time for no more." He drove his knife through the top of one of the bean cans, sawed out the top and passed the can to Lennie. Then he opened a second can. From his side pocket he brought out two spoons and passed one of them to Lennie.
- 14 They sat by the fire and filled their mouths with beans and chewed mightily. A few beans slipped out of the side of Lennie's mouth. George gestured with his spoon. "What you gonna say tomorrow when the boss asks you questions?"
- 15 Lennie stopped chewing and swallowed. His face was **concentrated**. "I ...I ain't gonna ...say a word."
- 16 "Good boy! That's fine, Lennie! Maybe you're getting' better. When we get the coupla acres I can let you tend the rabbits all right. 'Specially if you remember as good as that."
- 17 Lennie choked with pride. "I can remember," he said.
- 18 George motioned with his spoon again. "Look, Lennie. I want you to look around here. You can remember this place, can't you? The ranch is about a quarter mile up that way. Just follow the river?"
- 19 "Sure," said Lennie. "I can remember this. Di'n't I remember about not gonna say a word?"
- 20 "'Course you did. Well, look. Lennie—if you jus' happen to get in trouble like you always done before, I want you to come right here an' hide in the **brush**."
- 21 "Hide in the brush," said Lennie slowly.
- 22 "Hide in the brush till I come for you. Can you remember that?"
- 23 "Sure I can, George. Hide in the brush till you come."
- 24 "But you ain't gonna get in no trouble, because if you do, I won't let you tend the rabbits." He threw his empty bean can off into the brush.
- 25 "I won't get in no trouble, George. I ain't gonna say a word."

- 26 "O.K. Bring your **bundle** over here by the fire. It's gonna be nice sleepin' here. Lookin' up, and the leaves. Don't build up no more fire. We'll let her die down."
- 27 They made their beds on the sand, and as the blaze dropped from the fire the **sphere** of light grew smaller; the curling branches disappeared and only a faint glimmer showed where the trunks were. From the darkness Lennie called, "George—you asleep?"
- 28 "No. Whatta you want?"
- 29 "Let's have different color rabbits, George."
- 30 "Sure we will," George said sleepily. "Red and blue and green rabbits, Lennie. Millions of 'em."
- 31 "Furry ones, George, like I seen in the fair in Sacramento."
- 32 "Sure, furry ones."
- 33 "'Cause I can jus' as well go away, George, an' live in a cave."
- 34 "You can jus' as well go to hell," said George. "Shut up now."
- 35 The red light dimmed on the coals. Up the hill from the river a coyote yammered, and a dog answered from the other side of the stream. The sycamore leaves whispered in a little night breeze.
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Excerpted from *Of Mice and Men* by John Steinbeck, published by the Penguin Group.

## Annotations

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